



REFRAMING NEGATIVE THOUGHTS | EXERCISE 2

Asking The Question, 'What if?'

Think of an example where you are worrying about a future event and only seeing the negative possibilities.



Write down the issue, and then write down 5 'what if' statements with good potential outcomes.

EXAMPLE: For an organisation restructure where you may be worried about losing your job:

What if I get a new opportunity?

What if I get to learn new skills?



Whilst these new thoughts may not change the outcome, it will make you more energised and hopeful and may provide a new direction that you hadn't considered before.



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How to increase Positivity and Optimism - Best Practice



Avoid negative self-talk – after an event consider what you have learned and how you might apply that in the future rather than focusing on any negative aspects.



Challenge a negative thought – how accurate is it? Is it true to say that you 'never do anything right'?



Reframe the situation – look for ways to reframe an event in a more positive light.



Avoid jumping to conclusions: if a colleague appears distant or responds negatively towards you, rather than assuming it is something you did, consider what other outside influences may be impacting them.



Embrace challenges as opportunities for growth "I can't do this," becomes "I can't do this yet, but I'm learning."



Cultivate a growth mindset. Stimulating your brain with new skills/activities/learning can re-wire your brain, increase neural connections, positivity, and resilience.



Positive affirmations: "I can do this" "I've done this before and succeeded"



Re-direct your attention when re-living negative events/outcomes. Listen to music, walk, read a book.



Set realistic goals



Take time to savour and bank positive experiences into your long-term memory. Replay it several times in your memory and focus on how it made you feel.



Surround yourself with positive influences/people/support network: have lunch with positive colleagues and get their opinion on any ongoing challenges to get a different perspective.



Practice self-care: take care of your physical and mental wellbeing, including good nutrition, restorative sleep, and regular exercise.



Appreciate the small successes throughout the working day. Where you are involved in a major project, focus on the last few tasks you completed to give you a sense of achievement.



Cultivate positive thoughts, for example, rather than resenting time spent commuting, use it to learn a new skill or to review your ongoing tasks.



Make every situation a lesson learned: Review tasks or projects on completion: consider the challenges, what went well, and what you would do differently the next time to make the next project even more successful.



Use positive language in your workplace conversations to create a positive environment and make your team more optimistic about a project or deadline.



Express gratitude every day by reflecting on achievements, people, events, such as a successful presentation and make sure you thank people.



Find three positive aspects to every situation/challenge. For example, even though a team project is challenging positive aspects may be having the opportunity to work with the other team members or learn a new skill.



Participate in activities that reduce stress and boost mood such as socialising with friends, yoga, tai-chi, meditation, volunteering, physical challenges.



CBT (Cognitive Behavioural Therapy): identifies negative thoughts and challenges them with evidence.



Mindfulness & Meditation: Mindfulness involves being present in the moment and observing your thoughts without judgement and is a good way of breaking negative thought cycles.

Through the above strategies you can start to reshape your thought patterns and cultivate a more positive mindset to create a brain environment that's more positive and resilient.